

**July 2025**

# 16/2025: Prohibition of use of PFOS in fire extinguishing media

**Applicability: Shipowners, ship operators and ship managers, designers, ship builders and manufacturers.**

The IMO has developed amendments to SOLAS Chapter II-2 and the High Speed Craft (HSC) Codes (1994 and 2000) to prohibit the use or storage of fire-extinguishing media (including firefighting foams) containing perfluorooctane sulfonic acid (PFOS). The prohibition applies to both fixed and portable systems and equipment and enters into force on 1 January 2026.

These amendments were adopted after the following resolutions:

- SOLAS Chapter II-2 – MSC.532(107)
- 1994 HSC Code – MSC.536(107)
- 2000 HSC Code – MSC.537(107)

The following clarifications have also been published related to extinguishing media containing PFOS:

- IACS Unified Interpretation SC309 for SOLAS Regulation II-2/10.11
- IACS Unified Interpretation HSC11 for Regulation 7.9.4 of HSC Codes (1994 and 2000)
- The IMO has also published the same content as IMO MSC.1/Circ.1694 – Unified interpretations of SOLAS Chapter II-2 and the HSC Codes (1994 and 2000).

**New requirements**

These new requirements apply as follows:

- Ships constructed (keel laid) on or after 1 January 2026 and subject to SOLAS/HSC Codes must not use or store fire-extinguishing media (including firefighting foams) containing PFOS in concentrations above 10 mg/kg (0.001% by weight) upon the ship's delivery.

- Ships constructed (keel laid) before 1 January 2026 must comply with the above requirement no later than the date of the first survey* on or after 1 January 2026.



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- Disposal of the prohibited substances must be done using appropriate shore-based reception facilities.

- Any declaration issued by the fire-extinguishing media manufacturer should contain information about the extinguishing media such as, but not limited to - type, production period, batch number and reference to Type Approval/MED Certificate. It must also be kept onboard and made available to attending surveyors for review and verification that the fire-extinguishing media does not contain PFOS in concentrations above 10 mg/kg (0.001% by weight).

- For extinguishing media installed before 1 January 2026, where the maker's declaration or laboratory test reports are not available, sampling and testing of the extinguishing media onboard should be required to be conducted in accordance with a recognised standard (e.g. NPR-CEN/TS 15968) in order to verify that the firefighting media does not contain PFOS in concentrations above 10 mg/kg (0.001% by weight).

**What should shipowners and ship managers do now?**

By the first survey* on or after 1 January 2026, shipowners, ship managers and ship operators must ensure:

- They have evidence that fire-extinguishing media is PFOS-free or have arranged for the safe disposal of any prohibited fire-extinguishing media;
- Any replacement fire-extinguishing media or equipment has been suitably type approved;
- They update the vessel's inventory of hazardous materials after removal of any PFOS-containing fire-extinguishing media, as applicable.

***Definition of first survey**

According to MSC.1/Circ. 1290, the "first survey" referenced in SOLAS regulations, unless indicated otherwise, is the first annual, periodical or renewal survey due after a specified date in the regulations, or any other survey deemed reasonable and practicable by the Administration (having taken into account the extent of repairs and alterations being undertaken).

For a ship under construction where the keel is laid before a regulation's specified date, but the delivery is after that date, the initial survey is considered the "first survey".

**Future restrictions**

In the future, the EU, IMO and other regulatory bodies may introduce further restrictions on the use of fire-extinguishing media containing other chemicals in the PFAS group, such as perfluorooctanoic acid (PFOA).

**For further information**

If you would like more details or need support with these requirements, please contact statutorysupport@lr.org.



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